

CULTIVARS

→ Preludio

INTENSIVE SPACING

→ 4 rows per bed every 6" (15 cm)

FERTILIZATION

→ Fennel will do great in beds that were previously amended with compost and fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) meal and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

→ Drip tape (4 per bed) or sprinkler.

Irrigation Management

→ Root depth: Medium (24"-40")

→ General: Likes adequate moisture but not demanding.

IMPLANTATION

We grow fennels that are small in size — about 4 to 5 inches (10–12 cm). This allows us to have more units in a bed and grow them in shorter times. Mini-fennel is not overly popular at markets, but the restaurants we sell to always want some. It's easy to grow and does well in cold spring and fall. We plant some every 2 weeks to ensure a constant supply throughout the season. For every seeding, we plan enough beds for an estimated 3 weeks of supply.

In our planting program, mini-fennel is grouped with crops like lettuce, rapini, bok choy, mini-romaine, green onions, dill, cilantro and mini-kohlrabi — all crops that stay in the fields +/- 50 days and that have similar crop requirements.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- 30" bed prep rake
- Popping tray and marking roller

ITINERARY

- Remove tarp and clean out large debris. Use the rake if needed.*
- Uniformly apply amendments and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). To make transplanting easier (seeing as the soil is loose after being harrowed), we only prepare the beds when we are about to transplant.
- Pass with the dibbler-roller to mark the planting holes and bring out the well-watered trays.
- Once the beds are ready, 1 person will drop the seedlings while 2 others transplant the plants as fast as possible. 3 people/100'bed is a good ratio for efficient workflow.
- Install irrigation and water until the soil is deeply moistened.

* If the previous crop is too well established, or if the bed is too messy, mow the crop as low as possible and harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). Add 1" (2.5 cm) of compost evenly spread on the whole width of the bed and transplant into compost following a no-till strategy.

WEEDING

- 10–14 days after transplanting, use the bio disc to cultivate on the row and between the rows in one single pass.

PLANT PROTECTION

- No action is required

HARVEST

- Mini-fennel is harvested by one person who, straddling the bed, selects the largest fennel, cutting them at their base with a field knife.
- Size needs to be about 4 to 5 inches (10–12 cm). Only take fennel that is free from blemishes or soft spots.
- Make piles of 10 in the aisle and pick them up at the end.
- 1 person should harvest at least 100 mini fennel/hour.

CONDITIONING

- Mini fennels are washed using a pressure gun. Upon arriving from the fields, the bins are transferred to the cart and placed to the left of the sinks.
- Many fennel heads are placed side by side with the bulb facing the operator. The operator then sprays off any soil with the gun. Turn the heads over around and repeat. Then pile to the right.
- Once the pile has reached a certain height, put in storage bin and identify the bin.
- 1 person should package at least 100 heads per hour.

STORING

- Mini-fennels are stored in cold room kept at 35 °F (2 °C)